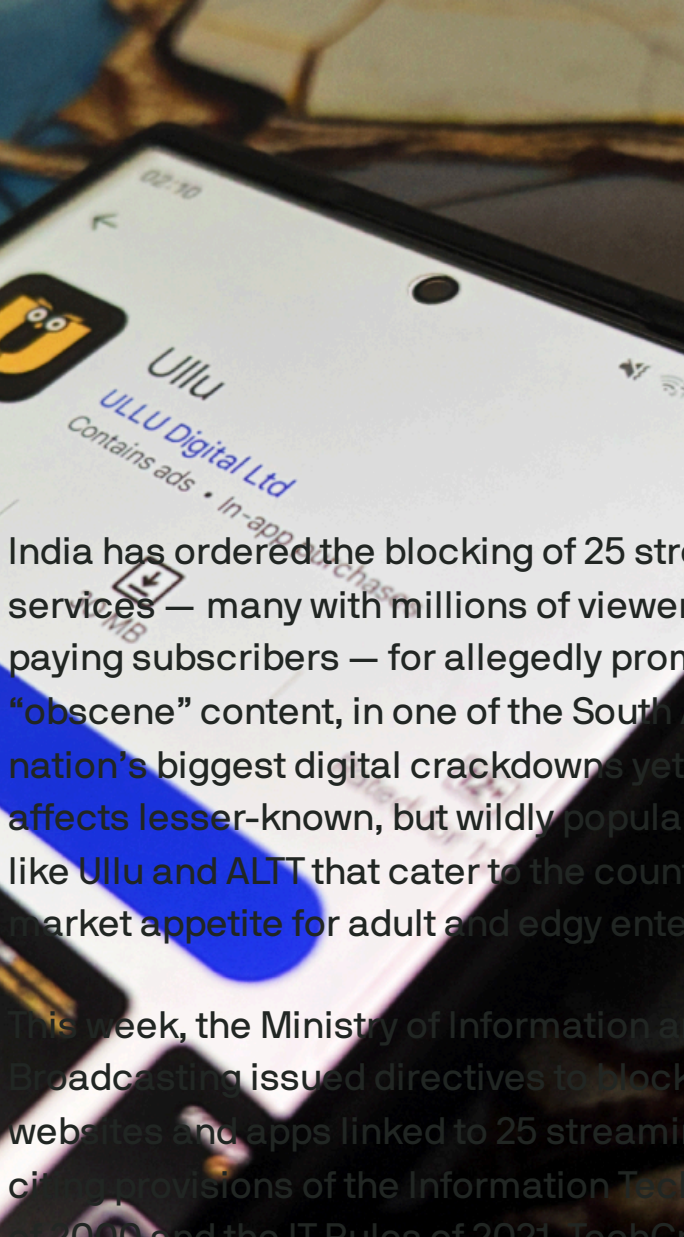


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GOVERNMENT &
POLICY



India bans streaming
apps you've never heard
of — but millions watch



India has ordered the blocking of 25 streaming services — many with millions of viewers and even paying subscribers — for allegedly promoting “obscene” content, in one of the South Asian nation’s biggest digital crackdowns yet. The order affects lesser-known, but wildly popular services like Ullu and ALTT that cater to the country’s mass-market appetite for adult and edgy entertainment.

This week, the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting issued directives to block access to websites and apps linked to 25 streaming services, citing provisions of the Information Technology Act of 2008 and the IT Rules of 2021, TechCrunch learned.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

The order came months after the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights and a Parliamentary Standing Committee on Information Technology raised concerns about mature content being streamed on these platforms without adequate safeguards.

The Indian government contacted internet service providers and app stores, including Google Play and the Apple App Store, earlier this week to restrict these streaming services, a source privy to the matter told TechCrunch.

Some of these services, especially the major ones with millions of subscribers, remained live at the time of filing this article.

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Google and Apple did not respond to requests for comment. The information and broadcasting minister also did not respond to an email sent Friday.

Of the 25 streaming services, 10 offered in-app purchases through their apps on Google Play and the App Store, generating a cumulative \$5.7 million since launch with nearly 105 million downloads, per the Appfigures data exclusively shared with TechCrunch. The wide gap between in-app purchases and downloads is primarily due to their low subscription costs — significantly lower than Netflix and other global platforms in India.

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TC

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Service	Net Revenue	Downloads
ALTT	\$1,700	57,900,000
Big Shots	\$2,900	5,700
Boomex		2,200
Bull		4,400
Hitprime	\$15,300	893,000
Hulchul	\$33,900	600,700
Jalva	\$18,600	611,000
Kangan	\$36,400	645,000
Look Entertainment		292,000
MoodX	\$13,570	1,513,600
Sol Talkies		8,100
Triflicks	\$80	
Ullu	\$5,600,000	42,500,000
Wow Entertainment	\$1,700	487,900

LIFETIME TOTALS OF BANNED STREAMING SERVICES FROM GOOGLE PLAY AND APPLE APP STORE

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

Notably, some of these streaming services were either never listed on traditional app stores or had been removed earlier, and instead offered their apps as direct APK downloads. As of publication, some of these APK files were still accessible through their websites or third-party platforms.

Earlier this month, Indian production company Balaji Telefilms, the parent of ALTT, [disclosed](#) that its streaming app generated ₹202.6 million (\$2.3 million) in revenue by adding 1.06 million subscribers in 2025. ALTT’s content was watched for more than 5.8 million hours, garnering 160 million annual views, the company said.

ALTT’s app was no longer available for download through Google Play and the App Store in India, and its website was inaccessible on most Indian ISPs at the time of filing this article.

Balaji Telefilms did not respond to a request for comment on the ban.

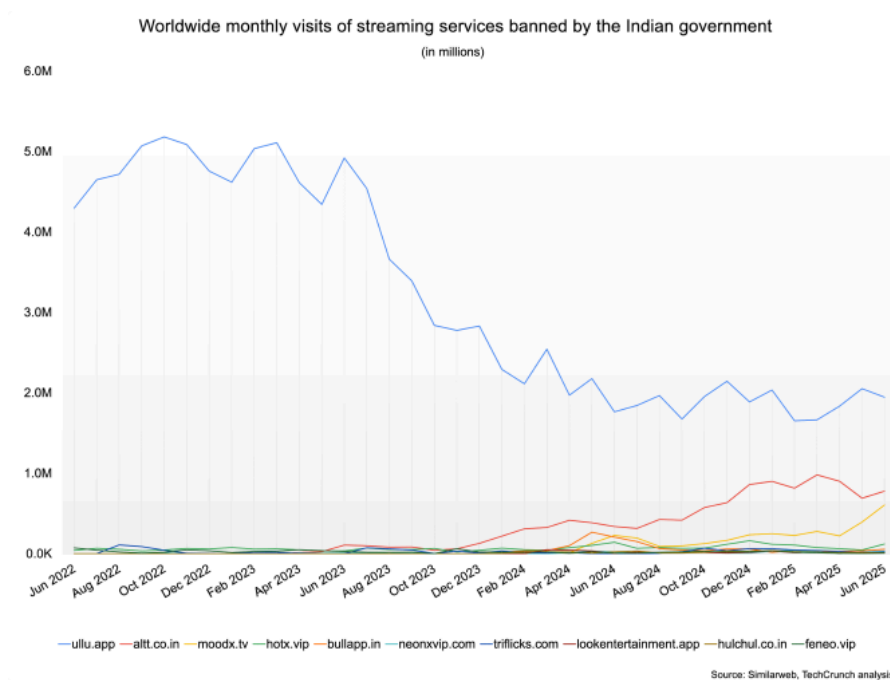
Ullu, another relatively prominent streaming service named by the Indian government, remained

available via its app on the Indian Play Store, and its website was accessible as well. The service's iOS app, however, was not available for download from the Indian App Store.

Ullu Digital, the parent company of Ullu, reported a net profit of ₹212.3 million (\$2.5 million) for the financial year 2024, per its regulatory filing reviewed by TechCrunch. The company posted a revenue of ₹931.4 million (\$11 million) and declared a net worth of ₹2.08 billion (\$24 million).

Ullu Digital did not respond to requests for comment.

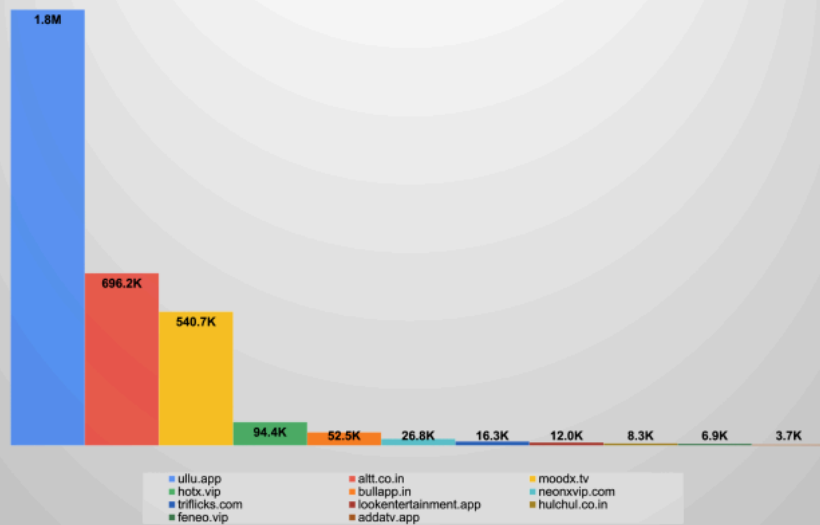
Alongside millions of dollars in subscription revenue, these streaming services were also attracting millions of global visits to their websites.



Ullu saw nearly 10% year-over-year growth in worldwide traffic, reaching 1.9 million visits in June, while ALTT recorded over 130% growth to 776,400, per Similarweb.

In India, Ullu recorded 18.9% year-over-year growth, reaching 1.8 million visits, while ALTT saw a 157.8% increase to 696,200 visits, Similarweb data shows.

June web traffic to streaming services banned by the Indian government in India
(Desktop and mobile visits, in millions)



Source: Similarweb, TechCrunch analysis.

Importantly, this is not the first time the streaming business has [seen a crackdown](#) in India. Global platforms, including Amazon Prime Video and Netflix, often [face instances of censorship](#) by the Indian government.

However, even stricter actions are seen in cases of obscenity despite a lack of clarity on regulations, as watching explicit content featuring fully consensual interactions between adult actors in a private space [is not a crime](#).

In 2023, the then Indian information broadcasting minister warned streaming platforms [not to serve abusive and obscene content](#). New Delhi has also blocked [thousands of websites streaming pornographic content](#). On a plea to regulate sexually explicit content in April this year, India's Supreme Court also [issued notices](#) to streaming platforms and the Indian government.

That said, curbing obscene content remains a challenge even for the Indian government. Smaller streaming services — like those targeted in this crackdown — often reappear under new names, apps, and domains. It is equally difficult for intermediaries like Google, Apple, and internet providers to fully block access, as these platforms often spread through alternative channels and use

social media platforms like Instagram and YouTube to attract viewers.

Topics: [ALTT](#) [Apple](#) [Google](#) [Google Play Store](#)

[Government & Policy](#) [India](#)

[Media & Entertainment](#) [Ullu](#)



Jagmeet Singh

Reporter



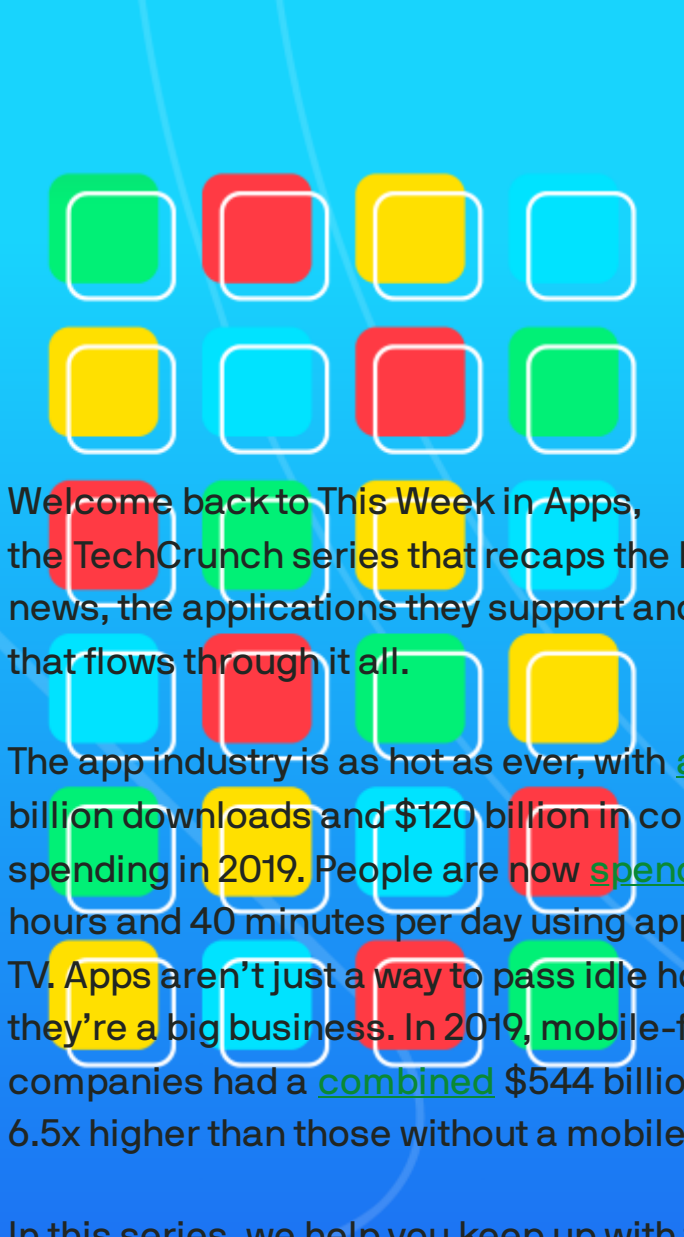
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**This Week in Apps:
Google Play gets new
rules, Apple launches
app marketing tools, EU
looks to rein in tech
giants**



Welcome back to This Week in Apps, the TechCrunch series that recaps the latest OS news, the applications they support and the money that flows through it all.

The app industry is as hot as ever, with a record 204 billion downloads and \$120 billion in consumer spending in 2019. People are now spending three hours and 40 minutes per day using apps, rivaling TV. Apps aren't just a way to pass idle hours — they're a big business. In 2019, mobile-first companies had a combined \$544 billion valuation, 6.5x higher than those without a mobile focus.

In this series, we help you keep up with the latest news from the world of apps, delivered on a weekly basis.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

Top Stories

Google changes its app store rules, too

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GOOGLE PLAY STORE SCREEN

Just a couple of weeks ago, Apple revised its App Store rules to permit game streaming apps and clarify rules around in-app purchases, among other things. Now, [Google has updated its rules](#), as well.

Under threat of regulation, Google announced this week it's updating its Google Play billing policies to better clarify which types of transactions will be subject to Google's commissions on in-app purchases. While the more detailed language doesn't actually change the earlier policy's intention, it will impact a percentage of developers who don't currently use Google Play's billing system when selling digital goods in their app.

In addition, the company announced it will make changes in Android 12 that will make it easier for users to install and use third-party app stores as an alternative to Google Play.

The company says that its current [billing policies](#) only apply to less than 3% of apps on Google Play. Of those apps, 97% already use Google Play's billing library. That means there's only a small percentage of apps that will need to come into compliance under the clarified terms.

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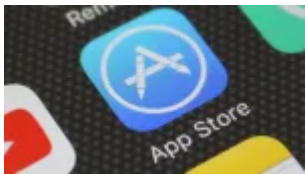
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App stores saw record 204 billion app downloads in 2019, consumer spend of \$120 billion



Consumers downloaded a record 204 billion apps in 2019, up 6% from 2018 and up 45% since 2016, and spent \$120 billion on apps, subscriptions and other in-app spending in the past year. The

average mobile user, meanwhile, is spending 3.7 hours per day using apps. This data and more comes from App Annie's annual [Continue reading](#)

The rules seem to want to bring into compliance larger services skirting in-app purchase rules, like Netflix and Spotify. But it's not clear yet how permissive Google will be about allowing apps to communicate alternative ways to pay. Currently, [Google says developers can tell users about how to sign up and use alternative payments outside of the Google Play app](#). But we don't know if Google will allow such a link to be prominently placed on an app's home screen, how it will allow such a link to be worded or whether an app can cater only to existing subscribers, and other key factors.

EU rule could force Apple and Google to share customer data, ban pre-installed apps

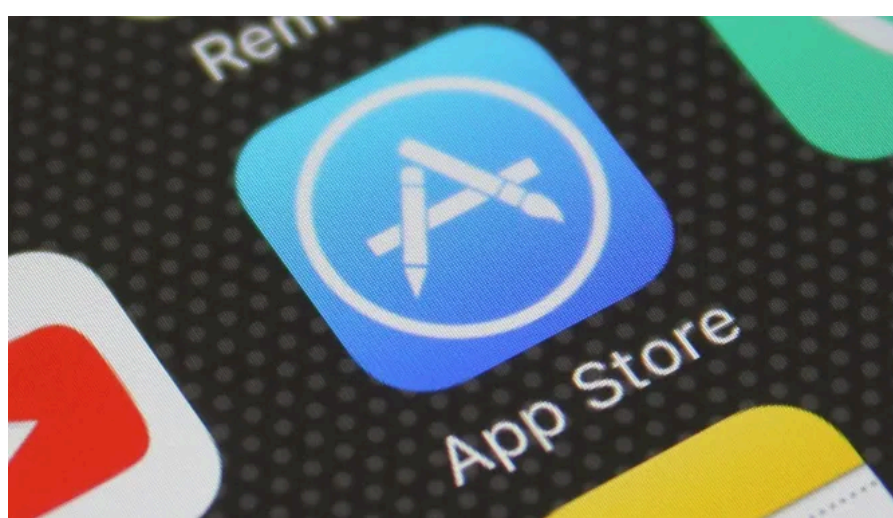


IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Major tech companies, including Apple and Google, may be required to share customer data with rivals, if a proposed EU rule, the Digital Services Act, comes to pass. The rule takes aim at anticompetitive business practices among tech's top players, like Apple, Google, Amazon and Facebook. One measure, detailed by [The Financial Times](#), says platforms can't use the data they collect for their own commercial activities [unless that's shared](#) with businesses pursuing the same activities.

The draft also currently recommends that big tech companies could be prohibited from favoring their own services on their websites and platforms, meaning they couldn't pre-install their own apps on laptops or phones, or forced businesses to pre-install their apps to gain access to their platform. In practice, that could mean Android phones that ship without Google apps, like Gmail or Drive, or iPhones without stock apps beyond those that offer core functionality, like the Camera.

In addition, another clause would ban the tech companies from blocking rivals that offer their products to customers outside the gatekeeper's

own platform, [Reuters reports](#). This could impact the current app store rules around payments and in-app purchases.

Google to better enforce Play Store in-app purchase policies, ease use of third-party app stores



Under threat of regulation, Google announced today it's updating its Google Play billing policies to better clarify which types of transactions will be subject to Google's commissions on in-app purchases. While the more detailed language doesn't actually change the earlier policy's intention, it will impact a percentage of developers who don't currently use Google Play's ... [Continue reading](#)

Anticipating regulatory pushback, Apple has made small concessions with iOS 14. Already, Apple had allowed users to delete some, but not all, of its stock apps. In iOS 14, Apple now lets users select their preferred web browser and email app, too. And both it and [Google](#) (see above) recently [modified their app store guidelines](#) to offer more clarity with regard to their right to collect platform fees in specific circumstances.

Apple and Google will, of course, object to any attempts at regulation. Google, in a submission to the Act, [argued](#) that a platform may only have market power in some sectors, but could be a new entrant or marginal player in others.

Weekly News Round-up

Platforms



App Store Marketing Tools

Boost your content with custom assets and links.

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IMAGE CREDITS: APPLE SCREENSHOT VIA TECHCRUNCH

Apple releases new app marketing tools. Apple [introduced](#) new tools that allow developers to generate short links or embeddable codes that link to their App Store product page. These can also display your app icon, a QR code or an App Store badge.

Second public beta of iOS 14.2 and iPadOS 14.2 arrive. The releases [bring](#) new emoji (see below), plus changes to the Now Playing screen in the Control Center and the Home app.

Apple's iOS 14.2 will bring new emoji. A new set of emoji are being [tested](#) in the beta version of iOS 14.2. The update will include the transgender flag, a smiling face with tear, pinched fingers, two people hugging, some insects and animals, a disguised face and more.

Google takes aim at beauty filters. Pixel phones will [update](#) to ensure face retouching features are off by default while labels and icons use “value-free” descriptions. The company said the decision to tweak the interface was based on expert recommendations over filters’ impact on people’s self-confidence and mental health.

Android Partner Vulnerability Initiative launches. The program will [focus](#) on managing security issues specific to Android OEMs, drive remediation and provide transparency to users about issues

Google discovered that affect device models shipped by Android partners.

Apple bans more RSS readers in China App Store.

Apple is still scouring its App Store for any services that don't comply with Chinese censorship laws. This week, RSS reader apps — Reeder, Fiery Feeds and [others](#) — [said their apps had been removed from the China App Store](#) over content deemed “illegal.” Fiery Feeds only had around 1,000 MAUs, but Feedly's latest app had 100K downloads.

Apple to release new emojis with iOS 14.2



While the current version of iOS is iOS 14.0.1, Apple is already testing iOS 14.2. The company released an early beta version of the update yesterday, and it includes a new set of emojis, as

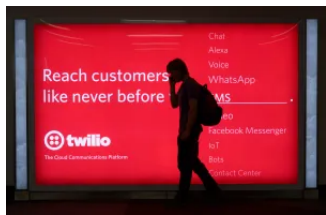
Emojipedia spotted. Apple already shared an early look of the new emojis back in July. Overall, there will be dozens

Services

Google Play Pass [launches](#) in 24 new European countries. The deal brings Google's subscription-based apps and games store to 34 total markets, including the U.S.

Twilio [launches](#) an app for frontline workers, a new IoT platform and a free video service, Video Web RTC Go. The latter allows you to add 1:1 video chat to mobile and web apps, like those aimed at distance learning or remote client consultations. It also launched Twilio Frontline, a React Native-based app for frontline workers who need to communicate with customers.

Twilio launches an app for frontline workers, a free 1:1 video toolkit and a new IoT platform



Twilio is hosting its annual Signal conference today and as usual, the company is using the event to launch a host of new products and features. For the most part, especially if you're a web or mobile developer, these are not

groundbreaking new features. The core Twilio services, after

Trends

Global Consumer Spending in Mobile Apps and Games for Q3 2020

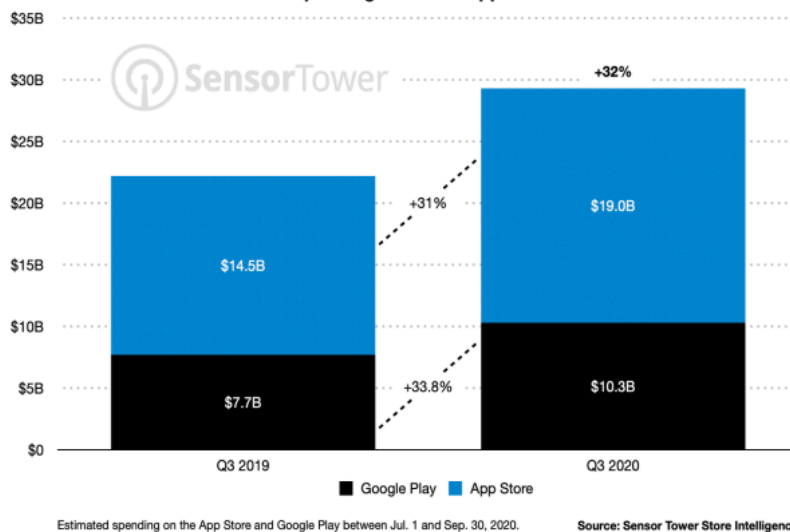
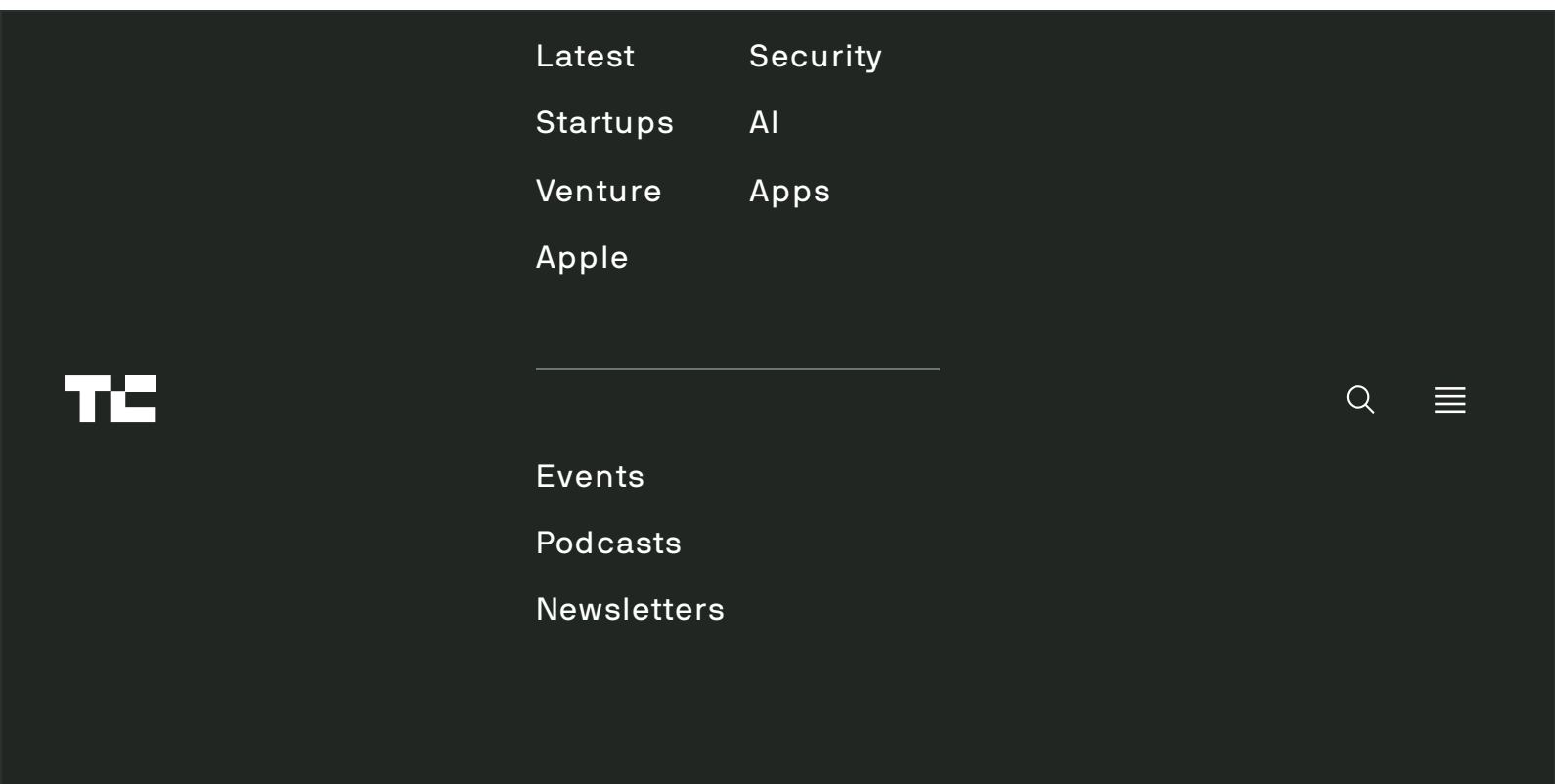


IMAGE CREDITS: SENSOR TOWER

Designer earns six figures in six days for iOS 14 icon set. In [a blog post](#), indie designer [@traf](#) details his experience building custom icons for the iOS home screen redesign trend. After a tweet showing off his home screen gained interest, he quickly created [a website to sell his icon packs](#). Then YouTuber MKBHD linked to him and soon, he was making big sales. The day after the video, sales jumped from \$6K to \$40K, and as of the time of writing the post this week, the set had earned him \$116,147.

Global app revenue up 32% year-over-year in Q3. Sensor Tower [reports](#) worldwide consumer spend

grew to \$29.3B and installs reached 36.5B across the App Store and Google Play in the third quarter. TikTok was the highest-earning non-game app globally and the most downloaded.



[by a judge](#), not a jury. Apple had previously been pushing for a jury trial, but withdrew its request. The judge suggested a jury trial is preferred, as it would have allowed real people to have a voice on what's shaping up to be a major anti-trust case. She [also had harsh words](#) for many of Epic's tactics and arguments presented so far, noting that walled gardens already exist elsewhere and Fortnite players have many other places to play besides iOS.

Astropad comes to Windows. A company [sherlocked](#) by Apple [brought](#) its Astropad system to Windows. The company's dongle turns an iPad into a second display, now for a Windows PC, a market Apple's [Sidecar](#) doesn't address.

TikTok's U.K. numbers revealed. A leaked marketing presentation [revealed](#) that 1 in 4 U.K. users now launch TikTok every month, with 17 million users spending over an hour per day on the app. That means the app has achieved a following almost

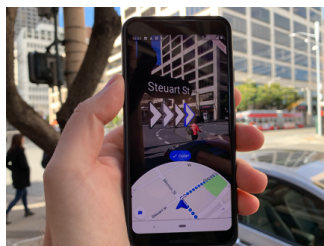
half as big as Facebook in the market in just three years.

TikTok launches a U.S. elections guide. The company [promised](#) not to save users' political affiliations for use in ad targeting or recommendations.

Google Maps rolls out improved AR directions. Google Maps [updated](#) Live View, its AR walking directions feature that launched last year. The feature, which uses the camera and GPS to help you navigate, can now be invoked from the transit tab, identify landmarks in major cities, and use Live View in combination with Google Maps' location sharing feature.

Microsoft's Bing search app will appear as a download prompt on new Android phones in Germany, the U.K. and France after it [won slots](#) in a Google auction for rivals.

Google Maps gets improved Live View AR directions



Google today announced a few updates to Live View, the augmented reality walking directions in its Google Maps app that officially launched last year. Live View uses your phone's camera and GPS to tell you exactly where to go, making it a

nice addition to the standard map-centric directions in similar

Funding and M&A, Etc.

Jamf acquires Mondada. MDM solution provider Jamf [bought](#) Melbourne-based Mondada, the maker of patch management solutions, Kinobi and Kinobi Pro. The deal will allow Jamf to expand Jamf's application lifecycle capabilities, it said.

Bloomscape raises \$15 million, acquires plant care app Vera. Online garden shop Bloomscape [raised](#) a \$15 million Series B from General Catalyst and others for its e-commerce business that ships live plants to customers' homes. It also bought Vera, a plant care and tips app, for an undisclosed sum.

Homer raises \$50 million. Early learning app maker [raised](#) \$50 million from Lego, Sesame Workshop and Gymboree for its apps that focus on early literacy and soon, more.

Humane raises \$30 million Series A to build the next iPhone...or something. Humane's ex-Apple founders, Imran Chaudhri and Bethany Bongiorno, haven't revealed what they're working on, but are [promising](#) to build something that's as groundbreaking as the iPhone. Chaudhri had worked on the original UI design of iPhone and iPad and Bongiorno helped launch iPad. They believe technology is a net negative for society as it's been built today, and their idea is to come up with a new computing vision entirely.

Macrometa raises \$7 million. An edge computing service for app developers, Macrometa [raised](#) a \$7 million seed round led by DNX Ventures for its Global Data Network that allows developers to send app requests to regions closest to them.

Beijing-based Sina Corp. [agrees](#) to go private in \$2.6 billion deal. The company is the latest to delist following growing scrutiny from U.S. regulators.

Downloads

HoloVista



Mixed reality storytelling developer Aconite launched its new, story-driven puzzle game [HoloVista](#) on iOS, where players explore environments with the iPhone's 360-degree camera in a mysterious mansion full of secrets. The game combines elements of hidden object search, puzzles and social media as you play as Carmen, a junior architect and new hire at an exclusive firm. The game also touches on themes like society's focus on social media, for example, and our relationship with technology ([\\$4.99 on the App Store](#)).

Macrometa, an edge computing service for app developers, lands \$7 million seed round led by DNX



As people continue to work and study from home because of the COVID-19 pandemic, interest in edge computing has increased. Macrometa, a Palo Alto-based startup that provides edge computing infrastructure for app developers, announced today it has closed a \$7 million seed round. The funding was led by DNX Ventures, an investment fund that focuses ... [Continue reading](#)

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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GAMING



YouTube and LinkedIn have games now, and here's how you can play them

Lauren Forristal — 12:00 PM PDT · July 7, 2024

The trend of media companies bringing games to their platforms has been unfolding in recent years.

In a world where user attention is increasingly competitive and attention spans are dwindling, streaming services and apps are looking for ways to captivate their audience. It makes sense for companies to expand into gaming to retain users on the platform: The global gaming market is worth around [\\$221 billion](#), making it an enticing revenue stream to explore.

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Latest in Gaming

Here are the latest companies venturing into the gaming scene and details about each offering, including pricing, examples of titles and supported devices.

Netflix Games

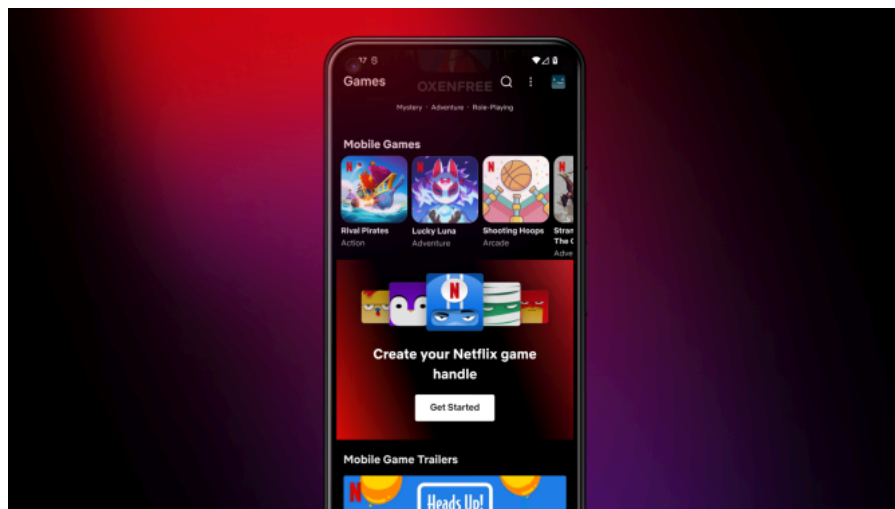


IMAGE CREDITS:NETFLIX

Netflix has a diverse portfolio of games, spanning nearly 100 games ranging from popular titles like [GTA: The Trilogy](#), [Assassin’s Creed](#), and [Monument Valley](#), among others. And, compared to other competitors on our list, Netflix has an upper hand thanks to its vast IP, boosting its library with games tied to original series like “[Love Is Blind](#),” “[The Queen’s Gambit](#),” “[Stranger Things](#)” and more.

Netflix’s gaming offering is free to subscribers of its streaming service and is accessible via its mobile app on [iOS](#) and [Android](#) devices. Players can browse the game library, and once they’ve made their selection, they can download the game separately from Google Play or Apple’s App Store.

People who want to try the games need to pay for a Netflix subscription: Standard with ads (\$6.99/month), Standard (\$15.49/month) and Premium (\$22.99/month). There are currently no [add-on purchases or ads](#), but that could change.

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GAMING



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GAMING



Google bets on STAN, an Indian social gaming platform

Jagmeet Singh - Aug 1, 2025

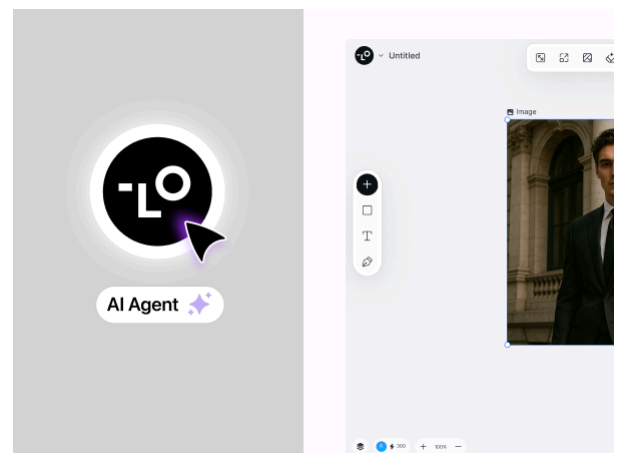
GAMING



Nintendo raising original Switch console prices due to ‘market conditions’

Aisha Malik - Aug 1, 2025

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Lovart’s design agent hints at the future: AI-native brands built in minutes

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Netflix [entered the gaming industry](#) in 2021, yet its offering didn't gain significant traction until recently, nabbing [81.2 million worldwide downloads](#) across the App Store and Google Play Store in 2023.



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The company has expanded its gaming section in many ways since its initial launch. For instance, it was recently [spotted](#) experimenting with the ability to play games directly in a browser. The company has also introduced [gamer tags](#) and is testing a [cloud gaming service](#).

YouTube Playables

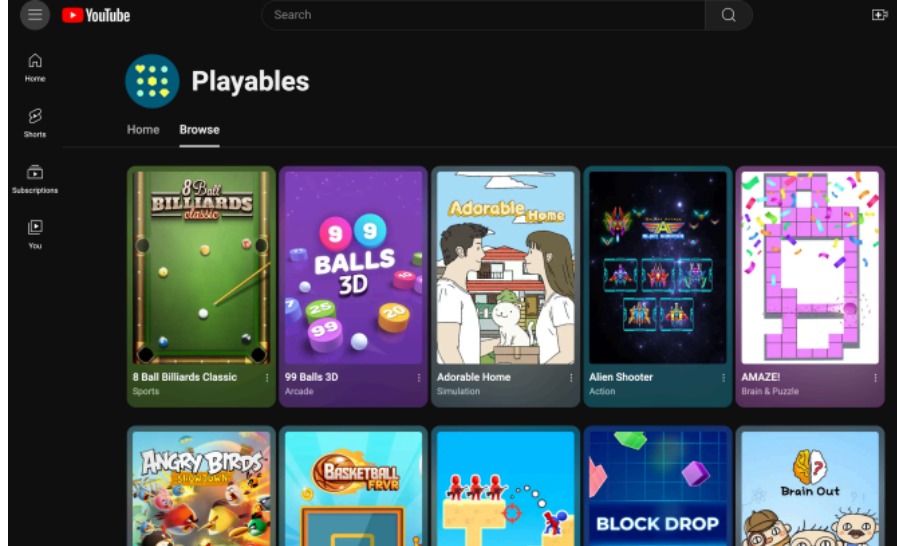


IMAGE CREDITS: YOUTUBE

Gaming seems like a natural avenue for YouTube to explore, since it's always been one of the go-to destinations for gamers to livestream sessions and create content about popular video games. The Google-owned video platform officially [integrated gaming features](#) into its service in May 2024, giving users access to over 75 minigames.

Called “Playables,” YouTube’s offering features a decent selection of titles, including popular games like Angry Birds Showdown, Cut the Rope, Trivia Crack and 8 Ball Billiards Classic, among others. The games are mainly designed to be an easy distraction for passing the time on a commute or to be played casually in between YouTube video viewing sessions.

While YouTube’s minigames were previously available only to [Premium subscribers](#), they’re now free to play for all users. The offering is available on desktop, Android devices and iOS devices. No downloads are required.

Sling TV Arcade

IMAGE CREDITS: SLING

As Sling TV faces challenges in keeping up with its competitors, the DISH-owned streaming service [launched a free gaming platform](#) called “Arcade” to attract and retain users. The new feature lets viewers play a variety of classic arcade games while simultaneously watching their favorite TV show or movie.

The selection of games is currently small, with only 10 titles available, including Doodle Jump, Solitaire Clash, Tetris and Wheel of Fortune. The company previously told TechCrunch that it would continue adding titles every few months, especially before popular sporting events.

While watching a show or film, press down on the player and click on “Interactive Features” to pull up the Arcade. After selecting a game, it will appear as a split screen next to the content you’re watching, which is convenient for lazy TV days when binging reruns of a reality TV show. There’s also an option to expand the game to full screen.

Arcade is available on Sling TV (\$40-\$45/month) and Sling Freestream, the company’s free ad-supported streaming service. However, it’s only on select devices at this time: Amazon Fire TV, Android TV, Comcast, Samsung and Vizio devices.

LinkedIn also has games

IMAGE CREDITS: [LINKEDIN.COM](#) UNDER A LICENSE.

Gaming is not exclusively explored by entertainment platforms. LinkedIn's entry into gaming marks a significant expansion for the company, positioning it as more than just a professional networking platform.

In an effort to attract more users, [LinkedIn announced in May](#) that it launched three games on its platform: a Sudoku-style game called Queens, a trivia game named Crossclimb, and Pinpoint, which is similar to the New York Times' Connections game.

Each game is meant to foster connection with people in your network and can be played with first-degree connections, meaning people you are directly connected with on LinkedIn. Games can be played only once a day.

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